Blue Blanket

By Andrea Gibson

INTRODUCTION

If you don't want to be raped . . .

- *Wear only modest clothing, covering all portions of your body that might be deemed provocative: shoulders, knees, stomach.*
- *Avoid swaying your hips when you walk,*
- *Always travel in groups; never walk anywhere alone*
- *Stay sober always; intoxicated women are asking for it.*

*When it comes to rape prevention nearly every article written is aimed at what **women** can do to protect themselves from potential rapists. The implied message is that if you put yourself in a compromising position, you shouldn't be surprised if you are raped. In other words . . . "It's your fault."*

Andrea Gibson addresses this societal misfocus of blaming the victim in her poem "Blue Blanket"

EDUCATIONAL

(Pg 36-39) Still there are days when there is no way,
not even a chance,
that I'd dare for even a second
glance at the reflection of my body in the mirror
and she knows why.

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Like I know why she only cries
when she feels like she's about to lose control.
She knows how much control is worth,
knows how much a woman can lose when her power to
move
is taken away

by a grip so thick with hate
it could clip the wings of Isis,
leave the next eight generations of your blood shaking.

And tonight
something inside me is breaking,

my heart beating so deep beneath the sheets of her pain
I could give every tear she's crying a year, a name,
and a face I'd forever erase from her mind if I could.

But how much closer to free would any of us be
if even a few of us forgot
what too many women in this world cannot.
And I'm thinking, "What the hell would you tell your
daughter?
Your someday daughter

when you have to hold her beautiful face
to the beat up face of this place
that hasn't learned the meaning of
STOP.

What would you tell your daughter of the womb raped
empty,
the eyes swollen shut,
the gut too frightened to hold food,
the thousands upon thousands of bodies used?

It was seven minutes of the worst kind of hell.
Seven.
And she stopped believing in heaven.

distrust became her law,
fear her bible,
the only chance of survival . . .
don't trust any of them.

Bolt the doors to your home,
iron gate your windows,
walking to your car alone
get the key in the lock like

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please please please please open
like already you can feel
that five-fingered noose around your neck
two hundred pounds of hatred
digging graves into the sacred soil of your flesh
please please please please open
already you're choking for your breath
listening for the broken record of the defense,
Answer the question,
Answer the question.
Answer the question, miss!

Why am I on trial for this?
Would you talk to your daughter,
your sister, your mother like this?
I am generations of daughters, sisters, mothers,
our bodies battlefields, war grounds
beneath the weapons of your brothers' hands.

Do you know they've found landmines
in broken women's souls?
Black holes in the parts of their hearts

that once sang symphonies of creation
bright as the light on infinity's halo?

She says, "I remember the way love
used to glow on my skin
before he made his way in
now every touch feels like a sin
that could crucify Medusa, Kali, Oshun, Mary
bury me in a blue blanket so their god doesn't know I'm a girl,
cut off my curls,
I want peace when I'm dead."
Her friend knocks at the door,
"It's been three weeks,
don't you think it's time you got out of bed?"
"No, the ceiling fan still feels like his breath,
I think I need just a few more days of rest, please."

Bruises on her knees from praying to forget.
She's heard stories of Vietnam vets
who can still feel the tingling of their amputated limbs.
She's wondering how many women are walking around this world

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feeling the tingling of their amputated wings,
remembering what it was to fly, to sing.

Tonight she's not wondering
what she would tell her daughter.
She knows what she would tell her daughter.
She'd ask her, "What gods do you believe in?
I'll build you temple of mirrors so you can see them.
Pick the brightest star you ever wished on.
I'll show you the light in you
that made that wish come true. . . "

Tonight she's not asking you what you would tell your daughter.
She's life deep in the hell, the slaughter,
has already died a thousand deaths with every unsteady breath,
a thousand graves in every pore of her flesh
and she knows the war's not over,
knows there's bleeding to come,
knows she's far from the only woman or girl
trusting this world no more than the hands
trust rusted barbed wire.

She was whole before that night.

Believed in heaven before that night,

and she's not only one.

She knows she won't be the only one.

She's not asking what you're gonna tell your daughter.

She's asking what you're going to teach

your son.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
Book: Pole Dancing to Gospel Hymns, Pg 36-39
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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
(Combined with Pinatas by Pages Matam and stored in the VAULT at Me Too – A Program)
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2020 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

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****Additional information about Victim Blaming can be found here from the Maryland Coalition Against Sexual Assault (2022)***

https://mcasa.org/assets/files/Victim_Blaming_Fact_Sheet_2022.pdf

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